



GLOBETROTTERS

Two out of four US Army Air Service Douglas World Cruisers completed the historic first aerial circumnavigation of the world on September 28, 1924. The journey of over 26,345 miles (42,150km) took five months. Here, the DWC New Orleans, is being launched from a ramp in Reykjavik, Iceland. Of the two airplanes that failed to make it, one struck a mountain in Alaska, while the other developed oil-pump failure near the Faroes.

newly formed Douglas aircraft company produce modified versions of the float planes it was manufacturing for the navy. Dubbed the Douglas World Cruisers, these four aircraft left

Seattle to make the first around-the-world flight in April 1924. It was a hard and halting journey, but two of the World Cruisers eventually completed the circuit five months later, having spent a total of fifteen and a half days in the air.

In Europe, where commercial aviation was more advanced and governments committed to

aviation as a focus of national prestige, long-distance flying in the 1920s focused on “trail-blazing” imperial routes, preparing the way for mail or passenger services that would link home countries to their far-flung colonies. Fliers were sent out to map remote areas, identify suitable landing sites, test weather conditions, and investigate ways over or around natural obstacles. This was the inspiration behind French pilots’ pioneering flights by across the Sahara to Dakar in French West Africa, and across Asia to Hanoi in Indochina (present-day Vietnam); of Dutch aircraft opening up routes across the Middle East and Southeast Asia to their Indonesian empire; and flights by the British via India to Australia, and via Cairo, Egypt, to South Africa.

Lacking an empire, Germany explored routes eastward across the Soviet Union, with which it had formed a close relationship as a fellow “pariah state.” In July and August 1926, the newly formed Deutsche Luft Hansa (DLH, later Lufthansa) airline sent two Junkers G 24s, state-of-the-art all-metal trimotor monoplanes, on a 6,000-mile (10,000-km) flight from Berlin to Peking via the Soviet cities of Moscow and Omsk. It was in its way a journey as adventurous as any in Africa or Southeast Asia.

Flying around the world

It was indicative of the backward state of US aviation in the early 1920s that the most prominent American long-distance flight was a propaganda effort to attract government funding and public support for the Army Air Service. The ever-publicity-conscious General Billy Mitchell had the

BYRD AND AMUNDSEN BATTLE TO THE NORTH POLE

IN THE 1920s Norwegian explorer Roald Amundsen (1872–1928) – the man who had beaten Captain Scott to the South Pole in 1911 – launched a bid to become first to fly over the North Pole. After Amundsen’s first attempt failed in 1925, he found himself in a race with US Navy Commander Richard E. Byrd (1888–1957), who had the same ambition. Byrd signed up two pilots (a mail pilot called Charles Lindbergh applied for the job but was too late) and took a prototype trimotor Fokker to King’s Bay, Spitzbergen, Norway. In May 1926, Amundsen also arrived, this time in an Italian airship, the *Norge*, piloted by Umberto Nobile.

POLE PRETENDER?

On May 9, 1926, Richard Byrd set out on a 1,535-mile (2,455-km) circuit around the North Pole in this Fokker FVII, the Josephine Ford, piloted by Floyd Bennett. He claimed to have accomplished his goal in 16 hours.



TRANSPOLAR STAR

The airship Norge (“Norway”), was commissioned by Norwegian explorer Roald Amundsen for his attempt to fly over the North Pole. Piloted by Umberto Nobile, they made the 2,700-mile (4,300-km) trip between Norway and Alaska in 72 hours.

On May 9, while the *Norge* was still being readied for its attempt, Byrd flew off in the Fokker, piloted by Floyd Bennett, returning 16 hours later to announce that he had flown over the Pole. Somewhat downcast, Amundsen and Nobile set off two days later, successfully crossing over the Pole and flying on to Alaska between May 11 and 13.

Whether Byrd actually reached the North Pole subsequently became a subject of controversy. It is now generally accepted that he did not, and that Amundsen thus deserves credit for the first transpolar flight. Byrd is still credited with the first flight over the South Pole three years later, and is recognized as a great Antarctic explorer. The story of Amundsen and the *Norge* had a tragic coda. In 1928, the airship crashed on a second Arctic flight under Nobile’s command. Amundsen was among those who flew out to attempt to rescue the Italian and his crew. Amundsen and his pilot were lost without a trace, though Nobile was later rescued.



THE TWO CONTENTENDERS

Richard Byrd (left) shakes hands with Roald Amundsen in Spitzbergen, Norway. Although Amundsen resigned himself to having lost the race for the first transpolar flight, it was later shown that Byrd never reached the North Pole.

